

MIDDLE EAST - NORTH AFRICA

War, censorship and abusive laws: the challenges facing journalists from Gaza to Tunis

This year, the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region is the worst zone in the world for press freedom, with 18 out of 19 countries classed as being in a “very serious” (11) or “difficult” (7) situation.

Flourish is disabled.

Allow

The legal indicator: a key factor

In this challenging context, **Syria** (which ranks 141st in the Index; +36 places since 2025) stands out for the historic transformation that has taken place since the fall of Bashar al-Assad in December 2024. Although the situation remains “very serious,” all five of its indicators are improving, particularly the legal score. While the legal indicator is in decline across most of the region, it has become the main driver behind improved working conditions for journalism in a country traumatised by years of brutal attacks on the press.

Qatar (75th, +4 places) has maintained its position as regional leader — a place it has occupied since 2023 — notably due to legal reforms introduced ahead of the FIFA World Cup in 2022. **Lebanon** (115th, +17) has also climbed up the Index, despite the war waged by Israel and persistent pressure on journalists. Renewed political will and a slight decrease in abuses against news professionals in 2025 have paved the way for a process designed to combat impunity for crimes against journalists and limit the use of non-specialist courts in lawsuits against media workers. **Palestine** (156th, +7) has also moved up in the rankings since the ceasefire with **Israel** (116th), in force since October 2025. More modest improvements have been observed in **Jordan** (142nd, +5) and the **United Arab Emirates** (158th, +6).

National security as a tool of repression

In contrast, press freedom has deteriorated in **Israel** (-4). Since 2023, the government has tightened “anti-terrorist” legislation targeting the press, imprisoned Palestinian and foreign journalists, and attacked journalists in Gaza, the occupied West Bank, East Jerusalem and Lebanon. More than 220 journalists have been killed in Gaza by the Israeli army since 2023, including at least **70 slain due to their work**, and no one has been held to account for these killings. In the Gulf, there have been notable declines in **Bahrain** (170th, -13) and **Saudi Arabia** (176th, -14), where the severe crackdown on journalism has led to journalists being imprisoned and even executed, like that of journalist Turki al-Jasser in 2025. Even countries that were already in fragile situations have fallen further down the Index over the past year. **Yemen** (164th, -10) has declined across all indicators, and **Iraq** (162nd, -7) has suffered deep structural fragility and seen a resurgence of violence against reporters. Despite the release of **high-profile** journalists in **Egypt** (169th, +1), the press remains subject to serious constraints. In **Iran** (177th, -1), near the very bottom of the ranking, US and Israeli strikes have, since March 2026, compounded the longstanding repression by the regime, which systematically threatens and arrests journalists and their families.

In North Africa, the decline in press freedom is no longer a temporary phenomenon; it has become structural, driven by political, economic and security dynamics that reinforce one another. In **Libya** (138th, -1), which is still a deeply divided country, journalists are often forced to serve one side of the conflict and are pushed towards self-censorship by an arsenal of legislation bolstered by a new cybercrime law. In countries not openly at war, obstacles to reporting are less visible but persistent. In **Algeria** (145th, -19), detentions, censorship and online harassment target independent newsrooms. Meanwhile, in **Tunisia** (137th, -8), political pressure and the instrumentalisation of the justice system are making journalism critical of the authorities an increasingly difficult task. Although **Morocco** (105th, +15) has seen an improvement, with no new journalists having been handed down prison sentences, news workers nevertheless remain exposed to legal and financial pressure.